

SprintLink

Micro Internship Marketplace

Short term paid project sprints connecting students with local organizations

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1. Executive Summary

Students are caught in a paradox: most internships require experience, but you cannot gain experience without an internship. Meanwhile, small businesses, nonprofits, startups, and campus organizations have real work to do across marketing, design, data, and operations, yet cannot justify a full time hire or a semester long intern. SprintLink is a two sided marketplace that connects the two through short, scoped, paid project sprints lasting a few days to a few weeks.

Hosts post a sprint with a clear deliverable, timeline, and stipend. Students apply, complete the work in a shared workspace, and get paid on approval through an escrow style payment flow. Every completed sprint becomes verifiable proof of experience on the student's profile and a pipeline of vetted talent for the host.

Why now

The shift toward project based and skills first hiring, the normalization of remote collaboration, and a generation of students hungry for real experience and income that fits around classes create an opening for a marketplace purpose built for short engagements, a need that traditional internship boards and general freelance platforms do not serve well.

2. Problem Statement

User problem (students)

Students struggle to land internships because nearly all require prior experience, referrals, or long application cycles. They need real, resume worthy projects and income, but cannot commit to full semester roles, and unpaid internships or vague volunteer work do not build a credible portfolio.

Market problem (hosts)

Small organizations need affordable, short term help with technology, marketing, design, data, content, and operations, but a full time employee or a traditional intern is too costly and slow. There is no simple platform focused specifically on short, project based work between students and small organizations; existing options are either full time job boards or broad freelance marketplaces that do not fit the student to small business sprint.

3. User Personas

Persona	Snapshot	Primary pain point
The Experience Seeker (Maya, 19)	College sophomore with real skills but no internship yet.	Every listing wants experience she has not been able to get.
The Recent Grad (Jordan, 22)	Needs portfolio pieces to stand out in a tough market.	A gap after graduation with nothing concrete to show.
The Small Business Owner (Lucia, 41)	Runs a local bakery and needs a landing page and social content.	Cannot afford an agency or a full time hire.
The Campus Organizer (Devon, 20)	Leads a student org needing a dashboard and an event app mockup.	No budget and no reliable help to get it built.
The Solo Founder (Aaron, 29)	Early startup needing market research and a Figma prototype.	Needs scoped help quickly without a long hiring process.

4. Goals and Success Metrics

Qualitative goals

- Give students accessible, paid, resume worthy experience that fits around school.
- Help small organizations get scoped work done affordably and quickly.
- Make completed sprints trusted proof of skill that leads to internships and jobs.

Quantitative targets

Metric	Baseline	Target	Measurement
Completed sprints in year one	New product	1,000	Platform analytics
Sprint fill rate	New product	70%	Platform analytics
Median time to fill a sprint	New product	Under 5 days	Platform analytics
Repeat host rate	New product	40%	Platform analytics
Student satisfaction after a sprint	New product	4.5 out of 5	In app survey

- **North Star metric:** completed, paid sprints per month.

5. Scope

In scope (MVP)

- Student and host signup with email and organization verification.
- Profile creation on both sides, with skills, links, and availability.
- Sprint posting, plus browsing with search and filters.
- Sprint application and host review, with accept and reject.
- A shared sprint workspace with messaging and deliverable submission.
- Host approval and an escrow style payment flow via Stripe Connect.
- Basic notifications, ratings after completion, and a basic admin dashboard.

Out of scope (for MVP)

- AI assisted sprint creation and advanced matching.
- Team applications, skill assessments, and verified skill badges.
- Campus ambassador program, organization subscriptions, and featured listings.
- A native mobile app and automated portfolio or resume generation.
- Advanced host analytics, school partnerships, and a full dispute mediation workflow.

6. Functional Requirements

ID	Requirement	Priority
FR1	Account creation with secure login, logout, and password reset for all roles.	Must Have
FR2	Student email verification (edu preferred) and host organization verification.	Must Have
FR3	Student profile with skills, school, resume and portfolio links, and availability.	Must Have
FR4	Host profile with organization details, logo, and verified status.	Must Have
FR5	Hosts can post a sprint with deliverable, timeline, stipend, and required skills.	Must Have
FR6	Students can browse, search, and filter sprints by category, pay, duration, location, skill, and difficulty.	Must Have
FR7	Students can apply to a sprint with a message and optional work samples.	Must Have
FR8	Hosts can review, shortlist, accept, or reject applicants.	Must Have
FR9	Each accepted sprint has a shared workspace with overview, messaging, and deliverable submission.	Must Have
FR10	Hosts fund the sprint before work begins; funds are held in escrow and released on approval via Stripe Connect on web.	Must Have
FR11	Hosts can approve a deliverable or request revisions.	Must Have
FR12	Both parties leave a star rating and written review after verified completion.	Should Have
FR13	Email and in app notifications for applications, status changes, deadlines, deliverables, and payments.	Should Have
FR14	Admin dashboard to view users, verify hosts, moderate listings, and resolve payment disputes.	Should Have
FR15	Skills based recommendation and matching of students to sprints.	Nice to Have
FR16	Completed sprints generate a portfolio entry and shareable proof of work.	Nice to Have

7. Non Functional Requirements

- **Payments and compliance:** an escrow style flow holds funds until approval; Stripe Connect handles payouts; payments run on web to avoid app store fees; payment states are explicit (pending, funded, in progress, approved, released, refunded, disputed), with tax and payout compliance handled as the platform grows.
- **Trust and safety:** email and host verification, report tools on listings, profiles, and messages, rules against unpaid work disguised as sprints and against unsafe projects, and admin moderation.

- **Privacy:** protect student personal data, collect minimally, set clear terms for revisions, deadlines, and payment release, and comply with applicable privacy law.
- **Performance and reliability:** marketplace pages load quickly, messaging and notifications are timely, and the platform scales as listings grow.
- **Usability and accessibility:** a mobile friendly, card based interface that meets WCAG AA and avoids overwhelming users with too many fields at once.

8. Risks and Assumptions

Risks

- **Vague sprint scopes:** unclear projects erode trust and cause disputes. Mitigate with required scope fields and listing templates.
- **Off platform payment:** hosts may try to pay students directly to avoid fees. Mitigate with the value of escrow, reviews, and clear policy.
- **Cold start:** a two sided marketplace needs both students and hosts present. Mitigate by launching campus or local first.
- **Labor concerns:** the platform must not become an underpaid labor marketplace. Mitigate with stipend norms and policy.

Assumptions

- Students will take scoped, paid work that fits around classes.
- Small organizations will pay for short, well scoped help.
- Completed sprints function as credible proof of experience.
- An escrow style model builds enough trust for both sides to transact.

9. Proposed Timeline

Phase	Focus	Duration
Discovery and design	Two sided user research, marketplace UX, scope templates, and Figma.	5 weeks
Build core (alpha)	Authentication, profiles, sprint posting and browsing, and applications.	8 weeks
Workspace and payments (beta)	Shared workspace, Stripe Connect escrow, approval flow, and notifications.	8 weeks
Closed pilot	Launch on one campus or local market and measure fill rate.	6 weeks
Public launch (v1)	Open signups with ratings and admin tooling.	3 weeks

10. Open Questions

- Do we launch campus first or local market first to solve the cold start?
- Should the platform fee fall on the host, the student, or be split, and at what take rate?
- What minimum stipend or scope standard prevents underpaid work?
- How much sprint scope should be required or templated before a listing goes live?
- Do we manually review listings at launch for quality, and when do we automate?

- What host verification standard builds trust without adding too much friction?

11. Appendix

- **Sprint definition:** a short, scoped, outcome based project lasting a few days to a few weeks, distinct from a traditional internship.
- **Example categories:** web design, social content, data cleanup, market research, Figma mockups, Notion dashboards, SEO, and operations support.
- **Data models (reference):** User, StudentProfile, HostProfile, Sprint, Application, Workspace, Payment, Review, and Notification.
- **Suggested stack (reference):** React Native with Expo and a Next.js web app, Firebase and Firestore, Stripe Connect, hosted on Vercel or Firebase.
- **Brand:** encouraging, professional, youthful, and opportunity focused; palette of navy, orange, teal, and blue.
- **Glossary:** sprint, host, escrow, take rate, fill rate, cold start.